Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters
Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election

Your Details

Name:[redacted]
Organisation (if applicable):
State/Territory:Qld in the electorate of McPherson
Contact email: [redacted]

[redacted]

I would like to address the topic of Postal Ballot & Self-Return Envelope Addressed to misleading address (obviously political party address & not the Electoral Commission Office).

These are the reasons why it is concerning:

1. **Misleading and Confusing Return Addresses**

Using a **party-owned return address** on an envelope that contains a postal ballot is **inherently misleading**.
Voters could easily assume that their vote is being sent directly to the AEC when in fact it is being sent to a **private or partisan address**.
Because it is unclear who owns or controls that address, the practice can **deceive voters** and **compromise public confidence** in the impartiality of the election process.

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2. **Lack of Oversight by AEC or Postal Officials**

When postal votes are returned to a **political party office** instead of the **Australian Electoral Commission (AEC)**, they are **not being handled by authorised AEC staff or Australia Post officials**.
This raises immediate questions:

- Who is opening or managing the envelope if it is not sent directly to the AEC?
- How can voters be certain that their ballot papers are remailed to the correct official address and not intercepted, delayed, or misplaced?

Without independent handling by electoral officers, there is **no guarantee** that a vote reaches its intended destination securely and confidentially.

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3. Concerns Regarding Voter Privacy and Anonymity

The **secret ballot** exists to ensure that an individual's choice remains known **only to them**, free from scrutiny or influence by others.
When a political party acts as an intermediary in the postal voting process, the **privacy and anonymity** of the voter are put at risk.
The handling of envelopes containing identifiable information creates the potential for votes to be **linked to individuals**, undermining the core democratic principle of **freedom of choice without fear or pressure**.

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4. Freedom from Influence and Undue Pressure

Voters must be able to exercise their choice **independently**, without fear that their decisions will be tracked or used against them.
There are serious concerns that ballots sent through party offices could be **monitored, recorded, or used to build voter databases** for future political targeting — including through social media or direct campaigning.
Such practices threaten the voter's **protection from undue influence**, which is essential to the spirit of the secret ballot.

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5. Integrity of the Electoral Process

The strength of Australian democracy depends on **public confidence** that every vote is private, secure, and counted fairly.
If postal ballots are diverted through partisan channels, it raises doubts about whether the process is truly impartial.
This undermines confidence in the **integrity of election results**, and invites concerns about potential **interference, tampering, or manipulation**.

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6. Conflict of Interest

Political parties have a clear **vested interest** in election outcomes.
Allowing them to **handle or collect postal vote materials** introduces an obvious **conflict of interest**. Parties could:

- Intentionally or accidentally **delay or obstruct** delivery of certain ballots.
- **Selectively collect** or fail to forward particular envelopes.

- **Harvest data** about who has returned postal votes and use it for targeted campaigning. Has my information been entered into a database, is it being monitored and used for social media influence – are my concerns.

Such practices blur the line between **partisan activity and public administration**, which should remain strictly separate.

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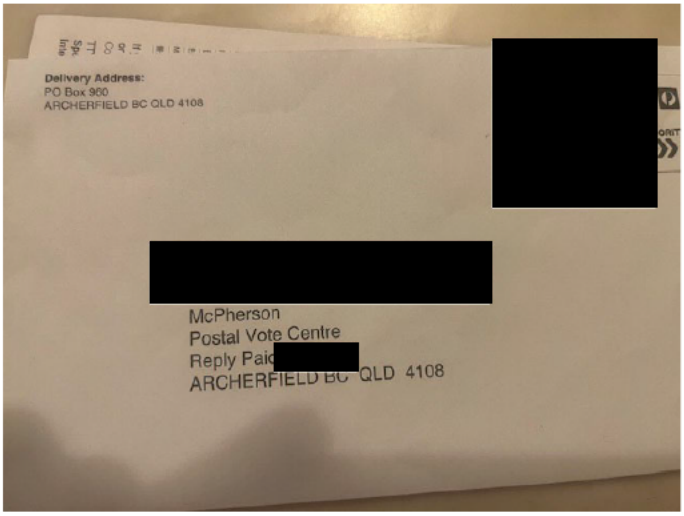
7. Risk of Privacy Breaches

Because these envelopes contain **personal identifying information**, sending them to political party offices risks **breaching privacy laws**, particularly under the *Privacy Act 1988 (Cth)*.
Voting behaviour and political opinion are classified as **sensitive information**, and the collection of such data by political entities without explicit consent is unacceptable.
For this reason, **postal votes should only ever be sent directly to the AEC** — not to any political organisation.

Conclusion

Allowing political parties to handle or redirect postal vote envelopes:

- **Compromises voter privacy**,
- **Erodes trust** in the electoral process, and
- **Violates the spirit of the secret ballot** that underpins Australian democracy.

To protect all voters equally, postal ballots should **only be sent and processed by the Australian Electoral Commission**, ensuring neutrality, integrity, and public confidence in our elections.